

Contribute to SharedVehicles to Help Solve Urban Transportation Woes



In many cities, worldwide, commuters face many problems on a daily basis. International agencies like the UN are trying to get the world to cut down on pollution by reducing vehicular emissions. So, can the free and open source concept of technology come to the planet's rescue with a viable out-of-the-box solution to protect the environment and help the urban commuter?

The open source campaign has been a great and very successful technological movement. It's interesting to see the words 'technology' and 'movement' together, because they usually belong to completely different spheres of human activity. Because of the efforts of pioneers like Richard Stallman and Linus Torvalds who worked against the odds and firmly established legal, technological and, most importantly, the cultural foundations of the open source movement, we are fortunate to enjoy the fruits of the hard work of thousands of hackers, free of cost. The Linux operating system is a fine testament to what can be achieved by volunteers working in a spirit of cooperation and sharing knowledge freely. Free and open source software (FOSS) is now firmly established in the sense that it is no longer battling for survival, but for improvement, and there are loyal communities of hackers and users around the world who keep the FOSS world running.

Practising openness beyond software

If we look closely, this is not just a technological

phenomenon, but something much more than that. It is very much like a social movement involving the fight for freedom, justice and equality. It is also a cultural movement that practices and encourages questioning, creativity and volunteer participation. Because of this tremendous success, the FOSS movement started having a significant impact on other spheres. The first and obvious impact was on software businesses, with many companies changing their business models in which *production* was no longer in the hands of just a few in the company. Because electronics and computer science are very closely related, there has also been an open hardware movement, with many successful projects like Arduino. Other initiatives include making some government data public under the *open data* policy by many governments around the world, so that researchers, social activists, the public and software developers can use the data in their own way. We even have an *Open Source Drug Discovery* project. So where else can we apply this idea of 'open source'? Can we solve the urban transportation problem, for example?